KERALA



MOST WANTED

Rape allegations against Congress MLA roil Kerala

By **Jeemon Jacob**

FOR A STATE THAT WEARS ITS GENDER Development Index on its sleeve, Kerala never ceases to shock with its toxic masculinity. On November 26, it got a smooth new face—Rahul Mamkootathil, Palakkad MLA and, till recently, a rising young star of the state Congress. His profile is eye-catching: only 36, an education CV that counts a Master's from St Stephen's in Delhi and an ongoing PhD, assembly debutant with a record win in a November 2024 bypoll, popular legislator thereafter, the recipient of admiring newspaper profiles while being a regular orator on TV debates with a large social media footprint.

That spring didn't last long. In a season of outrage that began in August, he was first called out by women Congress members, including a former MP's daughter. The complaints grew with every testimony alleging a familiar kind of predator: someone who gained proximity as a party acquaintance, then transited to a sender of lewd messages, trying to inveigle his victims into sexual liaisons, often by promising marriage and then weaseling out, often leveraging his rising power graph. As the news emerged, he quit as state chief of the Youth Congress, but otherwise brazened it out.

His luck ran out in November as an alleged rape victim filed a complaint with the chief minister's office. Her later police statement, parts of it reportedly corroborated by an audio clip and screenshots, makes for a disquieting story. It begins as Rahul came into contact with her on social media—she had then just ended a brief marriage due to domestic violence.

The accusations that ensued were a classic blend of coercion and blandishment. Starting with a sleazy wedding proposal—that since she was a separated woman, his parents would accept her as his bride only if she was pregnant with his child. The script thereafter: rendezvous at her flat and elsewhere, allegations of forced sex, intimate videos, threats to ruin her life and, finally, a coerced abortion.

Takeaways

- **Rape survivor files complaint against Rahul Mamkootathil**
- **Other testimonies, a second rape allegation bolster case**
- **Denied bail, he is absconding**

A POLITICAL STORM

As a formal case was booked, a TV anchor-cum-actress also made public his loaded messages to her. Mamkootathil went absconding on November 28. A manhunt is now on with the sessions court in Thiruvananthapuram denying him anticipatory bail on December 4. Sources say the rape allegations of a second victim, a 23-year-old from Bengaluru, weakened his case. The Congress had earlier suspended him as a phalanx of state leaders like V.D. Satheeshan, Ramesh Chennithala and K. Muraleedharan urged expedient action. Explusion came after bail was denied.

A section of the local Congress—including ex-state chief K. Sudhakaran and incumbent Sunny Joseph—had initially sought to defend him as the victim of a "CPI(M) conspiracy". Meanwhile, right-winger Rahul Easwar, too, backed Mamkootathil vociferously—and promptly got arrested for allegedly exposing the victim's identity. Even BJP mayoral candidate and retired DGP R. Sreelekha courted a public mishap by denouncing the victim for having a relationship with Rahul as a married woman.

Sexual predators come in all ideological flavours in Kerala. In October, the RSS was rocked by the suicide of a member, a young techie, who alleged years of sexual abuse at its camps. And the CPI(M) has Kollam MLA, actor M. Mukesh, who still serves even while facing investigations in an alleged rape case. The Congress didn't waste the chance to point at the irony of the CPI(M) taking on a pious tone with "a rape accused in their midst". A woman CPI(M) leader did not help by saying the Mamkootathil case was "extreme" while the Mukesh one was "low intensity". None of that may save the Congress from an all-consuming taint in the local body polls due on December 9-11. ■